

Chapter 16

RETURNING TO KERALA

'Can you get me a drink?'

On 20 December 1994, the return journey from Chennai to Ernakulam began. I was relieved, thinking that the ordeal is over and we would be released on reaching Kerala.

Inspectors Narpath Singh and Dhariyal took us to the train. P M Nair and R S Dhankar were in a coupe. The CBI team soon got information that the news of our return has been leaked and the media was thronging the Ernakulam railway station. The team decided to take us to Alwaye, and from there to Ernakulam by road.

The next morning we got down at Alwaye. Though it was an unscheduled break, a large crowd had gathered to see the spies. Mariyam Rasheeda and I were the prime attention.

As I was escorted out of the station, a young man shouted, 'Nambinarayana …'

I turned around and stood there, staring at the crowd. Some shouted *charan* (spy) and *rajyadrohi* (traitor). I stood composed. Once the shouts subsided I looked at the young man who had shouted my name and said aloud, 'Aniya (brother), you will soon know I am not a spy, just a victim of a conspiracy.'

Before he could react, the policemen took me inside a van.

We reached the Chief Judicial Magistrate court by noon and were soon remanded in judicial custody for fifteen days. The next stop was the CBI